

Ownership, implementation orientation, and the ability to work across business, technology and people are more important than they were five years ago"

SAURABH CHHAJER
MD & PARTNER, RECRUITMENT LEAD, BOSTON CONSULTING GROUP INDIA

challenges as organisations undertake large-scale AI transformations".

In the consulting business, how the client views and wants measurable outcomes is key. "Therefore, ownership, implementation orientation, and the ability to work across business, technology and people are more important than they were five years ago," says Chhajer.

THE GEN Z ANGLE

How does all that strike the right chord with Gen Z? RPG's Goenka is clear that Gen Z and generations after them may not automatically equate an MBA with career security. "There are many pathways to success and with an impetus to entrepreneurship, many want to build their own ladder. They also bring a stronger expectation of purpose, transparency and continuous learning into the workplace," he says.

Accordingly, the tack to reach out to them must be unique. At IIT Bombay, a large chunk of the class of 2026 opted for a job in place of going to the US for a master's or joining a B-school in India.

First off, recruiters spanned technology, core engineering, finance and quantitative trading, and consulting. A quick look at the list of companies on campus seals the discussion – Google, Microsoft, Amazon, Apple, Texas Instruments, Goldman Sachs, Barclays, Accenture, McKinsey and BCG, among others. Quite predictably, the number of students who took the Common Admission Test (CAT) to join the best B-schools dropped in 2025 compared to 2024 (see accompanying graphic).

"This cohort is pragmatic: they evaluate learning RoI, expect flexibility and care deeply about purpose, values, wellbeing and speed of growth," says Birla's Ramachandran. "Besides, they have more credible alternatives amongst which are micro-credentials, specialised masters, gig/creator pathways and early-stage start-ups."

THE AI CHALLENGE

AI presents another challenging frontier for B-schools and MBA programmes. When information and analysis are available at the click of a finger thanks to AI, what will students look for?



SOURCE MDRA

	Placement Performance (250)	Selection Process, Governance & Establishment (150)	Future Orientation (200)	Overall Score (1,000)
	231.3	137.3	164.9	**892.8**
	225.2	133.5	179.5	**889.8**
	221.1	133	175.3	**870.2**
	206.8	123.4	175.1	**842.7**
	202.3	132.2	175.1	**842.1**